

Grace Giving Vs Mandatory Tithe

prc-grace-giving-vs-mandatory-tithe

Money & Stewardship · Giving · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

breadth canon-wide

directness direct

variants stable

Statement under examination

Christians are called to generous, proportional, cheerful giving from a willing heart; the mandatory 10% tithe of the Mosaic covenant is not directly binding on the church, though tithing is a useful baseline.

In plain language

The Greek of the giving passages in this bundle speaks clearly about how Christians are to give. In 2 Corinthians 9:7 God loves a 'cheerful' (hilaron) giver, and Paul says the gift must not come 'out of grief or out of compulsion' (ek lypes e anagkes), but 'from a settled willing choice' (ek proaireseos). Strikingly, 'cheerful' (hilaros), 'giver' (dotes), and 'choose beforehand' (proaireo) are each used only this one time in the New Testament (each is a hapax, a word that occurs only once), packed into a single sentence, which makes the cheerful-giver clause unusually concentrated. In 2 Corinthians 8:3 the Macedonians gave 'of their own accord' (authairetoi), and 'according to ability' (kata dynamin). In 8:8 Paul insists 'not by command' (ou kat epitagen). In 8:12 the gift is measured by what a person has and by 'readiness' (prothymia). First Corinthians 16:2 ties the amount to however each one prospers. Taken together this vocabulary points firmly to giving that is willing, cheerful, and proportional rather than a flat legal quota. That is the part of the proposition the words strongly support. The harder question is the second clause, that the Mosaic ten percent tithe is no longer directly binding yet still serves as a useful baseline. The standard tithe word, 'tithe' (maaser) in Hebrew and 'to tithe' (apodekatoo) in Greek, never appears in the New Testament giving texts as a church-age command. But the canon also keeps a real tithe vocabulary: Abraham gives a tenth to Melchizedek in Genesis 14:20 before the Mosaic covenant is even given; Malachi 3 calls withholding the tithe robbing God; Jesus in Matthew 23:23 says of tithing, these you ought to have done; and Hebrews 7 clusters tithe-vocabulary around Abraham and Melchizedek. The texts themselves do not rank these two vocabularies against each other. The proposition asks readers to draw a line the words leave open: did the cheerful-giving vocabulary replace the tithe vocabulary, intensify it without removing it, or supplement it with a recommended baseline. Because the canon supplies both patterns and the giving texts neither repeat nor positively abolish the tithe word, the giving-disposition half is well established and the tithe-binding half remains contested, which is why the overall proposition is marked disputed.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H4643	מַעֲשֵׂה	maaser	tithe	32
H6906	רָבַעַ	qava	to rob	
G0026	ἀγάπη	agape	love	120
G0586	ἀποδεκατῶ	apodekatoo	to tithe	4
G0830	αὐθαίρετος	authairetos	self-chosen	2

G1181	δεκάτη	dekate	tenth	4
G1183	δεκατόω	dekatoō	to tithe	2
G1395	δότης	dotes	giver	1
G1411	δύναμις	dynamis	power	120
G1538	ἐκαστος	hekastos	each	91
G1729	ἐνδεής	endeēs	impoverished	
G2003	ἐπιταγή	epitage	command	7
G2129	εὐλογία	eulogia	praise	16
G2168	εὐοδόω	euodoo	to thank	4
G2192	ἔχω	echō	to have/be	
G2343	θησαυρίζω	thēsaurizō	to store up	
G2431	ἱλαρός	hilaros	cheerful	1
G4052	περισσεύω	perisseuo	to exceed	39
G4255	προαιρέω	proaireo	to predetermine	1
G4288	προθυμία	prothymia	eagerness	5
G5485	χάρις	charis	grace	176
G5532	χρεία	chreia	need	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The first clause of the proposition (New Testament giving is willing, proportional, cheerful) is lexically dense and stable: 2 Corinthians 9:7 commands a 'cheerful' (hilaron, G2431) 'giver' (dotes, G1395) and explicitly excludes 'out of grief or compulsion' (ek lypes e anagkes), pinning the gift to 'from prior choice' (ek proaireseos, G4255); 2 Corinthians 8:3 calls the Macedonians 'self-chosen' (authairetoi, G0830); 2 Corinthians 8:8 denies a 'command' (epitage, G2003); 2 Corinthians 8:12 measures by what one has, indexed to 'readiness' (prothymia, G4288); 1 Corinthians 16:2 ties the amount to 'as one prospers' (kata ho ti euodotai). The second clause (the Mosaic ten percent tithe is not directly binding) hangs on the silence of the New Testament giving vocabulary, which never uses 'tithe' (maaser, H4643) or 'to tithe' (apodekatoo, G0586) as a church-age command, plus the discontinuity signaled by 'not by way of command' (ou kat epitagen). But the canon also supplies a parallel tithe vocabulary spanning Genesis 14:20, Leviticus 27:30 to 32, Numbers 18:21, Malachi 3:8 to 10, Matthew 23:23, and Hebrews 7:2 to 9, which a continuity reading uses to argue the principle abides. The words do not rank these two patterns, so the negative half of the proposition and the useful-baseline rider remain genuinely contested at the lexical level.

Scripture

2Cor.9.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2431 ἡλαρός, G1395 δότης, G4255 προαιρέω

Force. The verse pivots on 'cheerful giver' (hilaron doten), whom God loves, and explicitly excludes the wrong motive with 'not from grief or from compulsion' (me ek lypes e anagkes). The giving flows 'from prior willing choice' (ek proaireseos). The cluster is unusually concentrated: 'cheerful' (hilaros), 'giver' (dotes), and 'choose beforehand' (proaireo) are each New Testament hapaxes (a hapax is a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament), gathered in a single sentence, which makes this the strongest single lexical witness that New Testament giving is governed by free, glad disposition rather than by a fixed legal quota. The grammar ('as he has chosen beforehand in his heart', kathos proeretai te kardia, present middle indicative meaning ongoing, simple statement of fact with the verb's subject acting on itself, with 'each one' (hekastos) as subject) locates the measure inside the individual heart, not in an external numeric standard.

1Cor.16.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1538 ἕκαστος, G2168 εὐοδῶ, G2343 θησαυρίζω

Force. 'Each one' (hekastos) is told to set aside and store up 'in keeping with however he prospers' (kata ho ti ean euodotai). The measure is indexed to personal prosperity by a present passive subjunctive (euodotai, an ongoing 'if he is prospered' form), a sliding proportional rather than a flat percentage rule. Notably Paul, having a perfect opportunity to install a Mosaic-style tithe statute for the Jerusalem collection, instead uses the open 'as one prospers' (kata ho ti euodotai) formula, supporting the proportional and willing emphasis of the proposition.

2Cor.8.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0830 αὐθαίρετος, G1411 δύναμις

Force. The Macedonians gave 'according to ability' (kata dynamin) and beyond, and crucially 'of their own accord' (authairetoi). The adjective 'self-chosen' (authairetos, G0830) is itself almost a New Testament hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament; here only at 2 Corinthians 8:3 and 8:17), and its components 'self' (autos) plus 'to choose' (haireomai) foreground self-chosen action. The pairing of 'according to ability' (kata dynamin, proportional) with 'of their own accord' (authairetoi, voluntary) twins the two governing categories the proposition asserts: ability and willingness, not imposed tithe.

2Cor.8.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2003 ἐπιταγή, G0026 ἀγάπη

Force. Paul states 'I am not speaking by way of command' (ou kat epitagen lego), framing the collection as a test of the genuineness of 'love' (agape) rather than a binding ordinance. The explicit denial of 'command' (epitage), the standard New Testament word for an authoritative command, is the clearest lexical signal that this giving is not legislated like a covenant statute. The grammar is a flat negative declaration, not a softening qualifier, so the disavowal cannot be read down.

2Cor.8.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4288 προθυμία, G2192 ἔχω

Force. The acceptable gift is measured 'according to what one has' (katho ean eche), and not according to what one does not have, with 'readiness' (prothymia) as the governing condition. The conditional 'if he has' (ean eche, a third-class 'if-then' clause using the present subjunctive of 'to have' (echo)) makes the standard floor-floating with actual capacity, not a fixed fraction. This is the clearest internal lexical statement that the operative standard is capacity plus willingness.

Acts.4.34 · neutral · genre: narrative

Key terms. G5532 χρεία, G1729 ἐνδεής

Force. The Jerusalem believers distributed 'as anyone had need' (kathoti an tis chreian eichen), so that no one was 'in need' (endees). The measure here is recipient need met from voluntary sale of property, which is neither a tithe nor a fixed percentage. The imperfect 'they were selling' (ektonto) and the imperfect 'it was being distributed' (dieidoto), both ongoing or repeated past actions, picture an iterated voluntary pattern, not a single legal act. This narrative illustrates need-based generosity rather than a legal quota.

Mal.3.8 · complicates · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H4643 תָּעֵשׂר, H6906 קָבַע

Force. The verse uses 'tithe' (maaser) and the strong verb 'to rob' (qaba), framing withholding the tithe as robbing God. The grammar is direct address within covenant lawsuit ('rib', a legal-dispute speech form) speech, addressed to Israel under the Mosaic covenant. Its lexical force on the proposition depends on whether the addressees and obligations extend across covenants. Within Malachi the obligation is unambiguous; the question whether it transfers to the church is what the giving texts in 2 Corinthians 8 to 9 and 1 Corinthians 16:2 do not positively answer.

Matt.23.23 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0586 ἀποδεκατῶ

Force. Jesus says of tithing mint, dill, and cumin, 'these you ought to have done without neglecting the others' (tauta de edei poiesai kakeina me aphienai). The verb 'to tithe' (apodekatoo, G0586) is the technical Greek for tithing. The aorist 'it was necessary' (edei, a completed past action) plus aorist infinitive 'to do' (poiesai, a completed past action) is most naturally read as endorsing the Pharisaic tithe-practice on its own terms, but the discourse setting is mid-Mosaic-covenant rebuke of scribes and Pharisees still living under the law. The words by themselves neither extend the obligation to the church age nor cancel it, leaving the binding question genuinely open.

Gen.14.20 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H4643 תָּעֵשׂר

Force. Abraham gives Melchizedek 'a tenth of everything' (maaser mikkol) before the Mosaic covenant is given. The pre-Mosaic position of this act is the principal lexical basis for arguing that tithing is a creation-or-patriarchal principle that predates and survives the Sinai covenant rather than a covenant-specific statute. The text reports a single act and does not by itself codify a recurring rate, so it grounds the continuity argument without by itself imposing a rule on later generations.

Heb.7.5 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0586 ἀποδεκατῶ, G1183 δεκατῶ, G1181 δεκάτη

Force. Hebrews 7:2 to 9 concentrates a dense tithe-vocabulary cluster ('a tenth' (dekate), 'to take a tenth' (dekato), 'to tithe' (apodekatoo)) around the Melchizedek-Abraham episode, arguing typologically from Abraham's tenth that the Melchizedek priesthood outranks the Levitical. The author uses the tithe data to make a christological priesthood argument, not to install a church-age tithe statute; the lexical observation is that the New Testament does retain the tithe vocabulary as theologically significant while never repeating an Old Testament style legislative command for the church.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
2Cor.8.12	2Cor.9.7	tsk	1
2Cor.9.7	2Cor.8.12	tsk	1

2Cor.9.7	Deut.15.7	tsk	1
2Cor.8.15	Exod.16.18	tsk	1
1Cor.16.2	Gen.26.12	tsk	1
2Cor.9.8	2Chr.25.9	tsk	1
Heb.7.5	Num.18.21	tsk	1
Heb.7.2	Gen.14.20	tsk	1
Matt.23.23	Lev.27.30	tsk	1
Mal.3.10	Lev.27.30	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Mal.3.8-10 · addressed

The classic tithe-as-binding text uses 'tithe' (maaser, H4643) and frames withholding as robbing God ('to rob', qaba, H6906). The lexical question is whether the obligation is covenant-specific (Mosaic Israel under the temple system, where the tithe funds Levites and the storehouse) or trans-covenantal (carrying across covenants). The vocabulary in Malachi itself does not settle that scope question, and the New Testament giving texts (2 Corinthians 8 to 9, 1 Corinthians 16:2) neither repeat 'tithe' (maaser) nor positively abolish it. The verdict therefore treats this as a genuine complicating witness rather than a defeater of the proposition's first half, while acknowledging the second half (tithe not directly binding) is exactly where this text creates the tension.

Matt.23.23 · addressed

Jesus uses 'to tithe' (apodekatoo, G0586) and says 'these you ought to have done' (tauta edei poiesai). The aorist 'it was necessary' (edei, a completed past action) plus 'to do' (poiesai) naturally endorses the practice on its current covenantal footing; the audience is scribes and Pharisees under the Mosaic order, and Jesus is reordering priorities ('judgment' (krisis), 'mercy' (eleos), 'faith' (pistis) come first) without abrogating tithe. Whether the endorsement extends to the church or only describes faithful Mosaic-covenant practice is not adjudicated by the verb itself, so this remains a real complication rather than a closed case.

Heb.7.2-9 · addressed

Hebrews concentrates the tithe vocabulary ('a tenth' (dekate), 'to take a tenth' (dekatoo), 'to tithe' (apodekatoo)) around the Abraham-Melchizedek episode to make a priesthood argument: the Levitical tithe-collecting priests themselves implicitly paid the tenth through Abraham, so the Melchizedek (Christ) priesthood is greater. The author uses the tithe data theologically but never re-issues a tithe command to the church; the silence on a continuing rate is itself the lexical observation. The complicating witness is real (the New Testament retains tithe vocabulary as significant), but its weight against the proposition's first half is small and its weight on the second half is exactly the contested point.

Gen.14.20 · addressed

Abraham's pre-Mosaic tithe is the strongest case that tithing predates the Sinai covenant and so survives its abrogation. The lexical observation is that the text reports one act, not a recurring rate or a generalized command; whether the singular act founds a perpetual principle is an inference the verse itself does not make. The verdict registers this as a genuine anchor for the continuity reading without overreading a single narrative report into a binding rate.

Concordance traversed

G2431, G1395, G4255, G0830, G2003, G4288, G5485, G2129, G4052, G1538, G1411, G0026, G2168, G0586, G1183, G1181, H4643

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

2Cor9.7-proeretai at 2Cor.9.7: impact none. The verb 'has chosen beforehand' (proeretai), carrying the sense of prior choice, is marked with an editorial sigil in the supplied text but no competing reading alters the willing-heart sense; the cheerful-giver clause is stable across attested readings.

Heb7.5-apodekatoun-form at Heb.7.5: impact none. Westcott-Hort reads 'to tithe' (apodekatoin) against the Nestle-Aland 28th edition (NA28) 'to tithe' (apodekatoun); both are forms of G0586 'to tithe' (apodekatoo) and neither changes the verdict on whether the church is given a tithe-statute.

All anchor verses lie outside the 3 John ECM window (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants), so CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method) data is not directly examined; the flagged forms do not bear on the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

new_covenant_theology: affirms · Reads the Mosaic tithe as a covenant-specific statute superseded by the new-covenant pattern of free, proportional, cheerful giving in 2 Corinthians 8 to 9 and 1 Corinthians 16:2. 'Not by way of command' (ou kat epitagen), 'as one prospers' (kata ho ti euodotai), and 'of their own accord' (authairetoi) are taken as decisive that the church-age principle is grace-shaped willingness, so the tithe is not directly binding while the giving virtues are.

covenant_theology: disputed · Reads tithing as a moral-creational or patriarchal principle predating Moses (Genesis 14:20 Abraham, Genesis 28:22 Jacob) that abides as a baseline, with New Testament giving vocabulary intensifying rather than replacing it. On this reading the second clause (tithe not directly binding) is too strong, while the first clause (cheerful, proportional, willing) is affirmed; the proposition's useful-baseline rider is acceptable but framed too weakly.

dispensationalism: affirms · Sharply separates the law of Moses from the church age, so the tithe-statute lapses entirely with the rest of the Mosaic code and church-age giving is governed by the grace principle of 2 Corinthians 8 to 9. The proposition's not-directly-binding clause matches this reading exactly; the useful-baseline rider is accepted as wisdom but not as obligation.

trans-covenantal-tithe: denies · Treats Genesis 14:20, Leviticus 27:30, Malachi 3:8 to 10, Matthew 23:23, and Hebrews 7:2 to 9 as a single trans-covenantal witness (one that carries across covenants) that the tenth is the divinely set minimum, with New Testament cheerfulness and proportion language describing the spirit of giving above that floor, not abolishing it. On this reading the proposition's negative clause is wrong: the tithe remains directly binding, and Paul's silence is not abolition.

The verdict turns on the covenantal arc from Mosaic statute to new-covenant giving, hence redemptive-historical (reading Scripture along the storyline of salvation across covenants). The first half (giving disposition) is lexically secure across all four frameworks. The second half (tithe not directly binding) plus the useful-baseline rider is exactly where the frameworks diverge, because the canon supplies two parallel vocabularies (tithe-vocabulary in the Old Testament and Hebrews 7, free-giving vocabulary in 2 Corinthians 8 to 9 and 1 Corinthians 16:2) that the texts themselves do not rank against each other. The consolidated verdict is therefore disputed rather than a clean affirm.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What does the New Testament giving vocabulary (cheerful, willing, proportional, 'from prior choice' (ek proaireseos), 'not by way of command' (ou kat epitagen)) indicate about how Christian giving is governed, and does that vocabulary, together with the continuing tithe vocabulary in Matthew 23:23 and Hebrews 7:2 to 9, settle whether the Mosaic ten percent tithe continues as a binding obligation, lapses entirely, or persists as

a recommended baseline?

The original stem encodes two lineage-specific conclusions: that the tithe is not directly binding and that tithing is nonetheless a useful baseline. Both are positions held within particular interpretive lineages rather than neutral lexical observations. The verdict was derived on the original stem; the neutralized form makes the preloading explicit. The lexical data secures the giving-disposition portion (cheerful, willing, proportional) but cannot adjudicate the baseline policy claim, which is why the consolidated verdict is disputed.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2431
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1395
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0830
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4288
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H4643
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.9.7
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Cor.8.3
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Heb.7.5
interlinear	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Mal.3.8
interlinear	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.14.20
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Cor.8.8
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Cor.9.7
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.16.2

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent